I will not be great, but I'm grateful to get through
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by Momo333

Summary

The never ending war against the black tide has ended and Mydei is alive. Why is he alive?
Struggling to come to terms with his life once more when he threw it all away for the prophecy, he has to learn to come to terms with his own life and find its meaning once more, navigating through it as a broken man.

How lucky for him that Phainon is there to catch him when he falls.

Always there, and watching.

Or: Mydei has to learn how to come to terms with being alive after the war and how to navigate life with the baggages that the war has left on all of them. Phainon is there to help him.

Notes

Not beta read so do let me know if I made a mistake anywhere as English is not my first language!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

The war was over, finally.

Mydei could hardly believe it finally ended, and he didn’t know if he should laugh or cry once it did. It felt surreal. One moment he watched all his friends die one by one in the bloody battle against the Flame Reaver and the next one there was a pain blooming from his spine, the enemy’s sharp blade cutting through him.

When he took Nikador’s coreflame and learned of the prophecy “One day, you shall die with a wound in your back” Mydei knew what he signed up to. For one to live to see the Era Nova, they shall give their all to achieve the end of the prophecy.

And yet.

The first time he saw Trianne’s body something snapped in him. His goodbyes to the other heirs were hurried, and before he knew it, Mydei was alone in Castum Kremnos. The empty halls crawled with slaves of the black tide and Mydei fought to take back what was his rightfully.

Still.

Loneliness and the dead titan’s taunts in his mind were a slow killing poison, seeping under his skin and infecting his mind with thoughts. His routine was constant, fighting the black tide and keeping them from reaching Okhema. He did not eat nor did he sleep, having no need of it as a demigod now. Yet, the mind was a fragile thing playing tricks on him as he saw shadows of his past and companions in the enemies, killing them with his own hands again and again.

The next time he met up with his friends Mydei knew not how much time had passed. The final battle took place in Castum Kremnos just as did Mydei’s godhood start here, it ended at the same place.

The happiness he felt upon seeing his companions once again when they appeared was short-lived as the Flame Reaver revealed himself, stronger than he was before.

Mydei can’t remember how things happened after that.

How the news about Aglaea’s assassination has hit him, the Chrysos Heirs left without a leader yet they pushed forward for the final battle.

In his dreams he still hears the horrific sound of Trinnon’s spine breaking as one of the shadows impaled her, body falling from the sky limp as her bones broke with the impact.

The way the Flame Reaver took Castorice’s life in seconds, despite her ownership over Thanatos’ coreflame now.

Phainon’s scream as the otherworldly being has stabbed him, right through his tenth thoracic vertebra.

There are thousands of lifetimes worthy memories flooding his mind, familiar yet so different and at the moment of his death, Mydei thinks he might just go crazy in the end. After that, there is only silence.

Then, he awakes.

His eyes blink open slowly mind confused. He is… not dead. As he heaves in a breath, his lungs burn, his back aching and Mydei feels like he is choking on air. It takes him minutes to realise he is okay and he is being held- Phainon clinging onto him like his life depends on it, arms circling around Mydei’s chest and holding him up in his lap.

He looks… different. His eyes are as blue as ever, Aquila’s sky could never rival the beauty of those blues. He wants to speak to ask what happened, *why* is he alive. He does not when he sees the look in Phainon’s eyes, unable to name the feelings.

“Mydei.” The man smiles at him, his eyes teary and Mydeimos feels like he has been stabbed again.

“How- I died.” He speaks and Phainon visibly recoils at it, his arms tightening around Mydei’s body.

“Don’t worry about it.” Phainon says, as if that should calm down Mydei, whose heart is starting to beat erratically, breathing becoming shallow again. As if it should explain the halo behind his back and the wings, one black and one gold just as the body tight suit he is wearing.

Mydei wants to ask more, to demand answers, to know *why he can't rest in peace finally* .

He does not.

His eyes shift around and soon enough he sees Castorice sitting not far from him, just as shocked as he is. He tries to move and reassure her, pushing down his own feelings and confusion, burying it deep in his mind to deal with in the solace of loneliness so he does not have to deal with them, but he can’t even move as Phainon holds onto him.

“De, you’re alive too!” The high pitched shout comes from not far away and Mydei flinches. This is absurd, he shouldn’t be hearing it she died, he saw the body-

Trianne collides with his chest as she hugs him, and Mydei is a weak man, as he hugs her back. Thinking that he must be dreaming. None of this makes sense.

“How-” he croaks and turns his head again to look at Phainon who just smiles.

Mydei can’t remember how they get back to Okhema. He drifts in and out of consciousness, and has no mind to pay attention to who is the one that carries him back. Phainon looks like himself again, like the Phainon he knows and Mydei questions if what he saw was even true.

Aglaea is alive.

She looks just as haunted as Mydei himself feels like, periodically reaching up to touch her neck while they talk.

Her reunion with the triplets makes even Mydei tear up, cracks showing on her ever well crafted mask of demigod as feelings seep through it. Finally, his questions are answered. Somehow.

“I- used the power of Remembrance that Fuli gave me.” The outlander explains. As if those words would explain what happened. “Mem helped. I could only turn back time to the point that we arrived on Amphoreus, since I have memories- I *took* memories from that moment.” She speaks, gripping the camera in her hand. The words she speaks are foreign to Mydei’s ears, still lost in the knowledge that he was brought back to life. That he is alive. Again.

He is so tired.

It seems like she has more to say, her eyes shifting to Mydei and she opens her mouth to talk- Mydei feels a touch on his back. He shivers as fingers trace down his spine, settling over his tenth thoracic vertebra, covering it with his palm, the warm skin a contrast to how cold he feels despite Kephale's sun warming the holy city. His eyes shift, looking at Phainon by his side and the man smiles down at him. Stelle eyes Phainon, but does not say whatever she intended to.

"We are most grateful to you outlanders." Lady Aglaea speaks, bowing her head, followed by the other Heirs present.

"It's- nothing to the galactic baseballer, really!" She gives her a thumbs up with a grin and not for the first time Mydei wonders just how she moves on like nothing happened after the tales he was told of her encounters in other worlds.

Maybe for the nameless, saving a planet is really nothing.

Maybe, their life does not matter in the end.

Maybe all the hardships they went through has been for nothing more than the entertainment for Gods, far above their planet.

Mydei feels his mind slipping away, zoning out as the others continue to talk, while he drowns in his own thoughts and feelings, not noticing the worried look somebody keeps giving him. The moment of his death was a surprise, an unwelcome one.

The Flame Reaver has spoken to him in his mind, telling him tales about destroyed lives and sacrifices, telling him that it all was happening *for him* .

Because of him .

For his sake.

Just a moment of hesitation on Mydei's part was enough of an opening to meet his end, a cold blade piercing through his spine and for the first time in his life warm red blood spilled from his wounds. He recalls someone screaming his name but he can't tell who it was.

He does not realise the absence of his mind until there is a touch on his back again, making him jump as Phainon's arm slips around him. He does not question the act, just looks up at him questioningly.

"I think we should retire. We can discuss further things later, Lady Aglaea. We will make sure to come when Stelle and Dan Heng's friends visit to deal with the Stellaron." Phainon talks with a smooth voice and Mydei blinks, lost in what he is talking about.

Nobody opposes Phainon and they say their goodbyes, Mydei letting himself be pulled into a hug by each of Janus' Holy Maidens, and soon, they are already walking through the corridors or Marmoreal Palace.

He turns at the entrance, ready to go back to his people and the Kremnoan settlement. He might be tired, but now that he survived the duty of guiding his people forward on a more peaceful life falls up on his shoulders once more.

"Where do you think you're going?" Phainon's voice is soft, and he isn't teasing Mydei like he so often does. Phainon does not let go of him. Mydei barely registers the shift in movement, the subtle way Phainon angles him toward another path, a gentle but firm pressure at his back. He frowns slightly, but says nothing, too drained to argue. The palace halls stretch on, familiar yet distant, and before he knows it, they are standing before Phainon's chambers.

"Rest first," Phainon murmurs, opening the door with ease. "Your people will still be there tomorrow."

Mydei hesitates, caught between obligation and exhaustion. But Phainon's hand remains steady on him, and without truly meaning to, he follows him inside.

The room is spacious and cozy. Beige coloured walls and white curtains frame the space. There is a king sized bed pushed up against the wall with light blue sheets covering it. There is a seating area on the other side with a table that has scrolls and antiques scattered around it.

The peaceful idyll of it all is surreal. Merely hours ago Okhema has become one with the ground, Marmoreal Palace overtaken by the Council of Elders and destroyed, once they have slit Aglaea’s throat, the red tide trampling everything to the ground, the Chrysos Heirs unable to do anything as one by one they died in their fight.

And yet.

Mydei walks over and sits down, eyes scanning over the table before him without actually taking it all in.

He doesn't know how he feels.

Without realising it, Phainon is already beside him as he hands Mydei a chalice filled with pomegranate juice and milk instructing him to drink. He does not argue, but he does not answer either. Instead, he takes a slow sip of the drink, the warmth spreading through his chest, but it does nothing to thaw the ice inside him.

Phainon watches him for a long moment before setting his own cup aside. Then, without hesitation, he sits beside Mydei, close enough that their shoulders touch. Mydei does not move away.

He should. He knows he should. But the weight of Phainon beside him is grounding, something solid, something real. He is *here* , he is *alive* .

For the first time since waking up, he lets out a breath he did not realize he was holding.

They stay like that for a while, sitting quietly next to each other as time passes. Neither of them speak.

There is a sound.

It is distant, barely there- a faint metallic clang, coming from the city below where people are celebrating the end of the war and the black tide. It shouldn't be enough to set Mydei off.

But it is.

The moment it reaches his ears, his body betrays him. The tension coils in his muscles before he even understands why. His breath catches, shallow and sharp, his fingers clenching against his lap.

Suddenly, he isn’t sitting in Phainon’s room anymore. He is back on the battlefield, standing among the ruins of Castrum Kremnos, countless of titankin fallen around him as he continues to fight, with no end in sight, lasting forever. The air is thick with the scent of charred metal and blood, screams fading into the void. His hands- his hands are wet, slick with something dark and warm.

His own voice is lost beneath the roar of battle.

His chest tightens. His vision blurs.

No. No, not again.

The ghost of steel slicing through his back lances through him, sharp and phantom-like. The tenth thoracic vertebra-

A hand grips his chin, firm and steady.

"Breathe," a voice commands.

It is not the voice of war.

It is Phainon.

For a moment, Mydei doesn’t move, his body trapped between past and present. His breath is ragged, barely reaching his lungs. But then, Phainon’s touch anchors him- warm, unyielding, real.

"Mydei. Look at me."

Slowly, he forces himself to meet Phainon’s gaze.

The blue of Phainon’s eyes is darkened, intense with something unreadable. Concern? Fear? Or something deeper, something that has always lurked beneath the surface? Mydei does not understand the feelings that hide in Phainon’s open face.

Phainon cups his face fully now, thumbs pressing into Mydei’s cheeks, grounding him further. His grip is firm, but careful, holding Mydei in place without caging him. A finger ghosts over the tattoo under his eye, a fleeting touch at first. Then again. And again, until Mydei realises that Phainon is caressing his cheeks with a look on his face that the kremnoan man can not describe. Does not dare to.

" You're safe .*"*

Mydei lets out a shuddering breath, his hands reaching blindly-instinctively. Phainon catches them without hesitation, clasping them tightly.

" Stay with me. *"* Phainon says, softer now, though his hands do not loosen.

Mydei nods, the motion stiff, barely there. His body is still trembling, the weight of the past pressing on his spine like a phantom blade. He can’t breathe.

Phainon notices.

Without thinking, he moves closer, wrapping one arm around Mydei’s back, settling right above where the phantom pain is cutting into his spine, the warmth of Phainon’s body freezing him.

″ You're not there anymore. ″ Phainon murmurs, his breath warm against Mydei’s temple. ″ You’re here. With me. I will not let you be taken from me again. ″

The words should not feel like a vow. But they do.

Mydei does not respond immediately. His hands are still gripping Phainon’s arms, fingers digging in as if afraid to let go. And Phainon-

Phainon lets him.

He does not speak of it again. He does not ask questions. He simply holds Mydei until the tremors subside, until the air fills Mydei’s lungs without resistance.

Until Mydei is certain that he is still alive.

And that Phainon is still here.

Always here.

The silence stretches between them long after Mydei has steadied his breath. Too long.

Mydei sits stiffly, his body still pressed close to Phainon’s, but the weight of his shame starts to settle in.

He lost control again.

How many times did he hallucinate during long nights of his seclusion in Castum Kremnos? When the war cries of the black tide died down, and he had a few hours to rest, filled with horror and ache as he gasped for air trying to keep his sanity with the voice of Nikador in his head, and the cries of the black tide calling to him.

His fingers twitch where they still rest against Phainon’s arms, now acutely aware of the way they had clung to him. His grip had been desperate, needy. Weak.

His stomach churns.

Phainon must think- No. He doesn’t want to know what Phainon must think of him right now.

Slowly, he tries to pull away.

Phainon does not let him.

It’s subtle, the way Phainon keeps him in place, his hold never tightening, never forcing-but refusing to let go all the same.

Mydei swallows, his mouth suddenly dry.

"I’m fine now," he says, voice low, carefully measured. It’s a lie, but an easy one that spills from his lips, with practiced ease. One that he has told a thousand times before the war. One that he managed to believe himself sometimes.

Phainon hums in response. A simple sound, neither agreement nor argument.

Yet he does not move.

Mydei hates how easily Phainon sees through him.

Shame presses against his ribs, threatening to choke him. He can still feel the ghost of his own trembling, still remember how Phainon’s voice had pulled him back from the edge.

Phainon, who had not hesitated.

Phainon, who had held him together when he was unraveling.

Mydei clenches his jaw.

"You don’t have to-" his lungs ache again as he starts to say, dreading the moment Phainon will pull away and look at him with pity in his eyes. He does not want pity. He knows that’s all he is good for.

Phainon shifts.

Before Mydei can finish, Phainon shifts, pulling Mydei even closer, the white haired hero’s hands settling over his spine in a tender gesture.

Not gripping.

Not holding.

Just there.

Resting over vertebras, fingertips brushing against the sensitive skin on the dip of his spine, gentle in a way that is deliberate.

Mydei freezes.

It’s not a command.

It’s not even an insistence.

It’s a reminder.

Of what, he doesn’t know.

His body, however, does. The tension in his shoulders loosens before he can stop it. His fingers, curled into his palm, relax just slightly.

Phainon says nothing.

He does not tease. He does not reassure him with words. He does not tell him that he is not weak, that he should not be ashamed.

Instead, he simply stays.

Letting Mydei feel his presence.

Letting Mydei understand, without needing to be told, that there is nothing to apologize for.

That Phainon will be here, whether Mydei trembles or not.

Before Mydei knows, he drifts into a dreamless sleep, his body finally shutting down after everything he went through, exhausted.

It is the entry hour and sunlight filters through the curtains, its soft glow just enough to wake Mydei. His eyes flutter open, and for a moment, the weight of everything is still there, pressing down on his chest like an invisible hand. But today feels different, or perhaps the feeling of heaviness is just a little less suffocating.

He blinks a few times, staring at the ceiling above him, the soft creak of the bed beneath him familiar and grounding. The air feels cooler, fresher. The room, though still unfamiliar, has started to feel more like his room, than his own chambers at the Kremnoan settlement and more like a safe place. He's still in Phainon's chambers. His body tenses at the thought, but then he takes a slow breath and exhales, willing himself to calm his mind and thoughts.

This is where he's been staying for the past week, ever since he'd woken up. It wasn't just the war that had left him hollow- it was everything that had followed.

The city celebrated when Aglaea announced that the black tide was no more thanks to the Flame Chasers and the Outlanders combined efforts. What followed was three days of festival where they were paraded around for the citizens to ogle at. Mydei should have been used to it by now, by the courtesy of his station as a crown prince and yet.

Not once did he find himself barely able to breath, the loud cheers and crowd making his skin crawl and blood rush into his ear. It was always Phainon who was there and grounded him, with a touch, steering and shielding him from the thousands of eyes, always making up excuses for the two of them to leave, despite how the Council of Elders did not take it kindly.

He never left Mydei alone those times, a silent and constant company when needed, babbling when he felt like Mydei could use the distraction.

And Phainon refused to let him leave, always steering Mydei back towards his chambers when the Kremnoan wanted to leave. It was with no effort that he managed to keep Mydei here, the blonde haired Chrysos Heir too tired to put up a fight, and here, he could run away from the endless duties that had awaited for him with the war over.

The truth was, Mydei has not planned this far in the future. He made sure that his people will be taken care of, free of the burden that the first king, Gorgo and their Titan, Nikador placed on them with the Kremnoan dynasty. Mydeimos demolished it when he left for his never ending fight against the black tide.

And yet.

Here he was, in a world after the war, unsure how to proceed. His people still looked at him for guidance and it was once more his duty to be there for them.

He did not think this far. He expected to die and drift away to the afterlife to be reborn once more in the future, but that simply was not the case, and Mydei could not help the pain in his chest, telling him he is *worthless, thousands has died because of you so why do you get to come back and not them? Why are you so special? A traitor to your blood.*

The people of Amphoreus moved on with their life, as if nothing had happened. Mydei couldn’t blame them, they were unaware of the countless deaths that took place. They can’t know how Mydei has lost the people dear to him one by one, how he himself died in the final fight. He has no reason,

no *right* to feel angry, so he swallows his feelings, bottling everything up deep in his chest until it decides to burst through cracks that are on his well crafted wall to keep his emotions locked away.

But in Phainon's presence, something about the brokenness within him didn't feel so isolating anymore. The emptiness in him does not feel so hollow. The voices quiet down at a Phainon's simple and mindless touches. Mydei does not want to think about what that means, what Phainon's soft and following eyes mean to him. What it means for them.

The first thing he notices once he slips back to the present, is the quiet. It's almost unnatural how still the air is. No chaotic thoughts swirling in his head, no panic clenching his stomach. Just… peace.

A tray of food sits beside him, warm steam curling up from it. It's a simple meal- just a bowl of cooked rice and spiced vegetables. His stomach churns slightly at the sight, a small knot forming in his gut. But he's tired of feeling nauseous. Tired of resisting.

He reaches out slowly, his fingers brushing the edge of the tray. The sensation is so ordinary, so mundane, but it's enough to break the weight of the silence that has settled over him like a blanket. For the first time in a long while, he doesn't feel the need to retreat from every tiny decision. Without thinking, he takes the spoon in his hand and lifts it to his mouth.

The warm taste of the meal fills his senses- soft, gentle, nothing too bold. But it's comforting. There's something about the simplicity of it that eases the tightness in his chest, just a little.

He doesn’t feel the need to force himself to finish it, to rush through the motions. It’s just food. And it feels like a small, silent victory to let himself eat without hesitation.

Back in Castrum Kremnos when the war cries of the black tide did not cease, he went on without eating for days, for weeks fighting nonstop, living and dying, and hitting, and hurting- an endless circle of pain and fight. Maybe whatever was holding him together broke him back then. Maybe even before that.

His fingers brush the spoon again, bringing it to his mouth for another bite when a familiar presence shifts in the doorway. Mydei doesn’t look up. He doesn’t need to- it can be only one person here, in the private chambers of one of Okhema’s heroes. He knows it’s Phainon, his shadow, the one who has been there every step of the way since everything fell apart.

Without a word, Phainon steps into the room, his gaze soft and unassuming. He looks at Mydei for a long moment, silent but observant, before he places his own cup of tea on the nightstand and sits beside Mydei, close but not too close. Just enough that their shoulders brush together.

Mydei doesn’t move away. He should, he knows that, but the weight of Phainon’s presence next to him, so solid and unyielding, makes it harder to retreat. Instead, he takes a slow breath, allowing himself a moment to simply be. The room smells like *Phainon* , like rain and hyacinth, like the fresh dew of the morning from a life before the Titan’s, when rain has fallen in Amphoreus, a lifetime he does not know to be true or his hallucinations playing cruel tricks on him.

The minutes stretch between them, quiet, still. The only sound is the faint clink of Mydei's spoon against the bowl as he continues to eat. Phainon doesn't press him to talk. He doesn't fill the silence with empty words. He simply sits there, as if he knows that this- this small moment of peace- is enough for now.

Mydei finishes the last bite of food, the warmth of the meal settling in his chest. He places the spoon back into the bowl, finally setting it aside. There's no rush, no guilt.

The silence stretches longer, but this time it feels different. It feels like… comfort. Like something that isn't quite normal, but close enough.

Finally, Phainon speaks, his voice low, a steady anchor in the quiet.
"Good."

Mydei doesn't know why, but hearing the simple praise stirs something inside him. A part of him wants to shrink away, to dismiss it, but he doesn't. For some reason, he lets it linger in the air between them. His eyes shift to look up at Phainon, the Deliverer wearing a soft smile on his face, one that makes Mydei's chest ache with feelings he fought for years to hide and hold down.

Phainon's gaze is unwavering, but it's not pressuring. It's not demanding anything. Just a quiet acknowledgment that Mydei has taken another step, however small, toward healing.

The silence comes again, but this time, there's no need to fill it.

Phainon shifts, his voice soft as he asks, “ Do you want to go outside today? ”

The words catch Mydei off guard. It’s an innocent enough question, but the thought of stepping outside, of facing the world again, makes his chest tighten. He looks out the window, at the garden bathed in sunlight, at the world that seems so far beyond his reach right now.

With the outside world comes once more the expectations of people, their following gaze as if they know things, as if they know him- they don’t. With it comes his duties again, an endless meeting with the Council of Elders now that the war is over and Amphoreus is ready to flourish again.

But then he takes a slow breath. There’s no pressure from Phainon. No expectation.

Mydei nods his head just slightly. His lips part to say something, but he doesn’t. He doesn’t have to explain.

Phainon hums, his gaze softening as if he understands Mydei despite how he tries his best to hide his feelings, once again forging his mask of marble of the prideful Kremnoan Prince.

“ It’s okay. We can stay here today. There’s no rush .”

Mydei feels the tension in his chest grow. He doesn't- he is not some kind of damsel in distress who needs to be kept in his room, just because he gets visions of the war sometimes. Don't they all? Have they all- the Chrysos Heirs- not come back from the dead for who knows what reason? Mydei does not believe what Stelle said, that it was her powers and the Aeon beyond Amphoreus gazing up on them that brought him back. He can *feel* it in his soul, peaces yearning for Phainon, only feeling complete when he is in the company of the other man.

"I am capable of going into public." Mydei says, his fists clenching as he looks down at his lap, feeling helpless.

"I know." Phainon talks, his voice soothing Mydei's nerves, a hand hesitating to touch Mydei's bare knuckles, his gauntlets discarded the night before. "But I would rather not. Stelle and Dan Heng's friends were rather weird, when I met them." Phainon says catching Mydei's eyes and smiles at him, hand falling down beside Mydei's on his thigh, their fingers barely brushing.

Mydei wants to say something, to ask why as he himself has been swept up with dealing with the Kremnoan settlement and he missed out on meeting with the other outlanders. He was not keen on doing so either. He had nothing against them, but he just did not feel like socialising with strangers.

He remains silent in the end.

Alas, life has never gone the way Mydei wanted it to.

The Vortex of Genesis is cold, the vast nothingness looming overhead as Aglaea steps forward to take her place at the forefront. Mydei follows a step behind her, his posture rigid yet composed, though there is an underlying weariness in his movements. Phainon walks beside him, close enough that their arms brush as they move. It is not accidental.

The other Chrysos Heirs are present, standing in their usual clusters, watching the newcomers with quiet intensity. At the opposite end of the chamber, Stelle, Dan Heng, and three others- Welt, Black Swan, and Sunday as they were introduced, are waiting.

Mydei has never met them before, but he can feel their scrutiny like a weight on his shoulders. It is not quite hostility, nor is it the wary respect he is used to receiving. It is something else. Something that makes him uneasy despite the knowledge that these people are here to help them.

Aglaea, ever poised, gestures. “Shall we begin?”

The group settles in, but the air remains tense. The brown haired man with glasses looks around, his gaze flickers over each of them before landing on Phainon. There is a beat of silence. Then, he tilts his head ever so slightly, his brows drawing together. “Strange.” he murmurs, almost to himself.

Phainon stiffens at once, his expression carefully blank. “Something wrong, Mr. Welt?” His voice is light, but Mydei catches the edge in it.

Welt does not answer immediately. He studies Phainon for a moment longer, his fingers drumming absently against the table drawing his companions' gaze- especially Stelle. Then, he shakes his head. "No. I was mistaken."

Phainon doesn't relax. Mydei can feel the tension rolling off him, a subtle shift in his stance, the way his fingers twitch against his side before stilling entirely. He does not trust this man. Mydei doesn't blame him.

Aglaea clears her throat, regaining control of the conversation. "We understand you have come to secure the Stellaron. We are willing to cooperate- but we will not hand over Amphoreus' fate blindly."

Welt's eyes shift to the Goldweaver, his tone serious but not unkind. "We don't intend to dictate anything. But the Stellaron is still dangerous, even now. If we don't contain it properly, what happened before could happen again."

The mention of 'before' lingers uncomfortably in the air.

"What would the sealing imply, Mr. Welt?" Castorice's voice rings clear and eyes shift on her.

"It's rather easy, Miss Castorice. We would seal the Stellaron away, that is working as the current sun of Okhema, that Kephale bears on his shoulder."

There is silence at first. Then voices erupt.

“Kephale’s sun- you would throw Amphoerus into darkness yet again?” Tribbie asks, Trianne and Trinnon by her side shaking their heads.

“But the people- they know of no life without Kephale’s light. Its disappearance would cause chaos.” Phainon’s fist is clenched. He had seen what chaos and darkness does to people.

They all have.

Mydei’s eyes shift at Aglaea, the way she stands with a calculated look on her face is not a good sign.

“Silence.” She raises her hand, and the Chrysos Heirs quiet down.

The silence is thick, weighted with the gravity of their decision. Mydei watches Aglaea carefully, the measured way she breathes, the way her fingers barely flex. She is thinking, calculating every possible outcome before she speaks again.

“I brought you here, to be away from the council’s deceitful ears. Yet you bring this idea- that will undoubtedly cause an uproar in the citizens and the leaders of Okhema alike.” Her voice is clipped and Mydei feels the golden threads sharpen invisibly in the air.

“You misunderstand,” Welt interjects calmly. “The natural sun will return. Night and day will be restored to Amphoreus as they once were. The Stellaron’s influence has blanketed this world in unnatural light, but its removal will not mean darkness, only balance.”

“And how long till it returns? The people know nothing more than the everdaylight of Kephale for hundreds of years.”

“That… I can’t say for sure. We can only do our best to calculate and act according to that. But if it isn’t dealt with, it is only a question of maybe days, maybe years until the black tide returns, casting the world into darkness.” Welt answers.

The tension in the room shifts. A pause. Then murmurs among the Chrysos Heirs. Mydei breathes out slowly, rubbing his fingers together as he considers the implications. The weight of the war, the destruction, the years of rebuilding- it all ties back to the Stellaron, to the imbalance it created.

He feels Phainon’s gaze on him. When he turns his head slightly, he catches the glint in Phainon’s eyes, the rigid set of his jaw, a look that Mydei does not know of his friend, one that he did never see before.

And yet, there is something else beneath the surface. A flicker of paranoia, an unspoken dread. The threat of everything going back to how it was, their sacrifices pointless and the Era Nova being nothing but a lie. All of their lives and sacrifices being nothing but a lie.

“We will consider it,” Aglaea finally says, voice firm. “But we expect full transparency. The moment we sense any deception, the agreement is void.”

Welt inclines his head. “Of course.”

“The meeting is over. Let us gather together once the decision is made.” Aglaea speaks, her words closing the negotiations and everyone starts moving to leave.

Mydei releases a breath. He does not realize how tightly he had been clenching his fist, the metal of his gauntlets cutting into his flesh, until Phainon shifts closer, just enough that his fingers ghost over his own- brief, grounding, before curling slightly around his wrist. The touch is grounding, a silent reassurance- but also a quiet, possessive claim.

Mydei should pull away. But he doesn’t.

He does not realise the eyes of a woman with cards following him intently, curious and calculating as she tries to steal a glance from his memories.

At first, it’s barely noticeable- the change in the air. A sharp inhale, a shiver down his spine that he cannot place. Mydei is about to turn when he catches Welt’s eyes flickering to the side, sharp and assessing. He follows the glance and sees Black Swan sway.

Sunday reaches for her immediately, steadying her. But there's something *wrong* . Her fingers twitch around her ever-present deck of cards, her breath caught in her throat. It's subtle, controlled, but Mydei catches the smallest tremor in her hands, the tension in her frame.

Mydei frowns, taking a step forward towards the outlanders. "Are you-"

Her eyes snap to him. And for a split second, he feels like he's been *seen through* .

Not looked at. *Seen* .

Something flickers behind those deep, knowing eyes- something vast, as if she has glimpsed something that should not be seen. Her lips part slightly, her breath quick and shallow. Her grip tightens around her cards, and Sunday murmurs something to her in a low voice.

She does not answer him.

There is a movement at Mydei's side.

Phainon does not speak, does not reach for his weapon, does not even tense, but Mydei feels the shift. The subtle press of his fingers against Mydei's

wrist tightens, the weight of his presence settling heavier. He does not step forward. He does not move.

But he watches.

Not like a wary soldier. Not like an interested observer.

Like a predator who has just noticed another set of eyes where there should be none.

Black Swan’s breath hitches, her gaze darting to Phainon now. It lasts only a second before she composes herself, her usual smooth, knowing demeanor sliding back into place. She does not look at Mydei again.

She does not say a word.

The moment stretches too long, too silent, before Welt clears his throat, breaking whatever invisible current had begun to pull at the room.

“We will speak again soon,” he says simply, a finality to his tone.

The outlanders move first, filtering out. The negotiations are over. The decision is not yet made, but the weight of it lingers in the air.

Mydei shakes his head slightly, trying to dispel the strange feeling pressing against his ribs. It’s nothing, he tells himself. The meeting had been tense, the stakes high. That’s all.

And yet-

Phainon is still at his side. Close. *Too close.*

Mydei should step away, but he doesn’t. The warmth of his presence keeps him steady, something solid against the weight pressing against his ribs.

He exhales, forcing his fingers to uncurl from the tight fist they had formed. Phainon’s touch lingers, light against his hand, an absent gesture, nothing more. Mydei tells himself that’s all it is. That’s all it has to be.

He does not notice the woman watching, throwing a glance back at him as she walks out, nor the way her expression shifts. Stunned, shaken, as if she has glimpsed something she was never meant to see. But Phainon does. His gaze lingers on her for only a moment before he looks away, his hand steady, his presence unmoving.

“What do you say to eating golden honey cake?” His voice is light and there is a smile on his lips as he pulls Mydei, shielding him with his own body from the lingering gaze of the outlanders.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei stands at the edge of the balcony, his hands braced against the cold stone railing as he gazes at the artificial sun carried on Kephale's shoulders. Soon, it will be gone- sealed away, locked beyond reach. For so long, it had been Amphoreus' only light, and now, for the first time in centuries, true day and night would return.

He should be relieved. The world would be restored to what it once was before the Black Tide, before war carved its scars deep into its surface and deeper still into the hearts of those who survived. But instead of relief, an unease lingers in his chest. What will it feel like to live under a natural sky again? Will it feel different, or will it simply be another change he will have to learn to live with?

Mydei can't recall a lifetime where he saw the true sky, as it had been ruled by the Titans ever since the beginning of human time. Aquila and Kephale always kept their claim on the skies of Amphoreus.

The sound of footsteps approaches, steady and unhurried. Mydei does not need to turn around to know who it is, before Phainon speaks.

"It will be gone soon. To think that the reason we fought for centuries is the very reason that somehow kept us safe at the same time from the black tide…" Phainon says, his voice quiet and wondering. Mydei does not answer him.

He stops a step behind Mydei, close enough that Mydei can sense him without touching. "You should stay away from the outlanders, Stelle's companions."

Mydei exhales through his nose, not looking away from the horizon. "Why?"

Phainon does not answer immediately. Mydei can feel his presence shift, stepping beside Mydei, their hands only inches away on the railing, but not touching Mydei. “They don’t belong here,” he finally says. “And they don’t understand you. They want something from you. It seems like *she* wants something from you.”

A tired smile tugs at the corner of Mydei’s lips. “They want the Stellaron,” he says. “Not me.” He has no idea who she is, what Phainon is talking about and he feels too tired to ask.

Phainon doesn’t reply, and the silence between them stretches, thick with unspoken feelings and things. Then, a faint pressure- just the ghost of a touch- hovers at the base of Mydei’s spine, over his vertebrae. The Kremnoan does not know when Phainon moved his hand. Not touching, not pressing, but lingering just enough for Mydei to notice. His breath catches slightly before he exhales, willing himself to ignore the way Phainon’s presence coils around him like a shadow.

“I should go back to my people,” Mydei murmurs at last, his fingers tightening on the railing. “They need me.”

Phainon steps beside him now, close enough that their arms nearly brush. “They are settling in.” he says. “You will see.”

There’s no argument in his tone, but something in the finality of his words makes Mydei glance at him. Phainon’s gaze is unreadable, and Mydei doesn’t press. Instead, he lets Phainon guide him away from the terrace, back toward his chambers, where the world feels smaller, quieter.

The Kremnoan settlement looks just like how he remembers before his departure to stand guard for an eternity in Castrum Kremnos, before the black tide attacked again, before all of the Chrysos Heirs had fallen and time was reconstructed to bring them back into a more peaceful world. He still has problems believing it.

The settlement stretches before him, a city of white stone and sun-drenched courtyards, nestled against the cliffs that once marked the boundary

between survival and oblivion. Mydei walks through its streets, the scent of the mountains carried on the wind, mixing with the earthier aroma of fresh mortar and dust, the smell of iron and weapons being forged. The Kremnoans have wasted no time rebuilding the destroyed homes on the outskirts of Okhema, and building their own houses.

Columns rise proudly, carved with intricate patterns of weapons and laurels, standing like silent sentinels over the broad avenues. Homes are being reinforced, their domed rooftops glinting under the artificial sun that still lingers in the sky.

Children dart between the pillars, laughter ringing through the air, their sandals slapping against stone. Merchants arrange their stalls in the agora, displaying amphorae of oil and wine, rolls of fine-dyed fabric, and baskets of golden fruit- so painfully obviously Okhemans a stark contrast to Kremnoan practicality. But there are lingering warriors who look at the products, and maybe this small act of acceptance and integration is what Mydei needs to see. The people move with purpose, yet Mydei notices how most of them pause to pay respect with a knock on their chest as they watch him pass, their gazes respectful but expectant. He doesn’t know if they see him as their prince or as something else entirely- a ghost of the past, a relic of war.

At the heart of the settlement, an open-air temple stands, unfinished but already magnificent, its marble altar waiting for dedication. Mydei stops at its steps, running his fingers over the chiseled Kremnoan script etched into the base. A prayer. A promise. A plea for guidance to the God of Strife. The position that once belonged to Nikador, now has fallen on the shoulders of Mydei. Seeing his own face being carved into marble makes Mydei feel bashful- pink colouring his cheeks as he glances away, unaware of Phainon’s watchful eyes.

He exhales, steadying himself.

This is what he fought for. This is what they lost and reclaimed. And yet, as he watches the settlement breathe with new life, he wonders if it will ever feel like home again to his people.

A presence lingers just behind him. Phainon, quiet and watchful, his warmth at Mydei’s back. Mydei doesn’t turn, but he knows Phainon’s eyes are following him.

“You chose well.” Phainon says, voice gentle, as his eyes shift to run over the buildings and settle on the sculpture before him. “They’re thriving.”

Mydei doesn’t answer immediately. He looks toward the horizon, where soon, the sky will change. Where the false sun will vanish, and the real one will return.

“I hope so,” he says at last. “I hope it lasts.”

Phainon doesn’t reply. But when Mydei finally turns, he finds Phainon’s gaze fixed not on the settlement, but on him.

They reach the strategy room, the heart of Kremnoan governance, where decisions for the settlement are made. A grand hall lined with open colonnades, its central table is littered with maps, documents weighed down by small bronze statuettes. Mydei’s teacher, Krateros stands at its head, broad-shouldered and commanding even in his age, his arms crossed as he surveys them. As if he was expecting the prince to visit.

"Mydeimos." Krateros greets, voice measured but carrying an edge. "You finally come to see what you have built. And you have brought Okhema’s dog with you." The distaste towards Phainon is clear in his voice, making Mydei frown slightly.

There is something sharp in his words. Mydei inclines his head, stepping further into the hall. "I have seen it, Krateros. I walk among our people every day. And he is not a dog, he is a Chrysos Heir. You should know better than to insult him."

Krateros ignores his words about PHainon, and the white haired man altogether.

"Then perhaps you have seen what they refuse to say. That this is not Kremnos." Krateros' sharp eyes flicker toward Phainon briefly, then back to

Mydei. "You had the chance to reclaim what was ours, yet you chose to settle in the shadow of the Okhemans."

The air in the hall tightens. Mydei knew this conversation would come, yet exhaustion creeps in regardless. He already had this argument once in the past, before he left for Castrum Kremnos, his mother’s signet ring given up. He already denounced the end of the Kremnoan dynasty once.

"Castrum Kremnos is gone," he says, firm but without anger. "We could not rebuild it. The land was razed, the foundations shattered. The whole city is gone, nothing more than ruins. Okhema is stable. Our people need stability, not ruins."

Krateros exhales sharply through his nose. "So you would have us live among foreigners? With no walls of our own, no stronghold to call our own? You-"

"Enough."

Phainon’s voice is soft, yet it cuts through the tension like his blade cuts through titankin. He steps forward, not quite between them but close enough that Mydei feels the shift in power, the quiet claim on the prince’s personal space. His blue eyes, so often warm, hold an unspoken warning as he looks at Krateros.

"You speak as if Mydei has not already given everything.” Phainon continues, tone even but carrying weight. "As if your survival was not bought with his own blood. He took up Nikador’s coreflame and fought. He chose this because it is what will keep your people safe. Would you have him burn himself further just to chase a past that is gone, a glory that holds nothing but bloodshed?"

Krateros' jaw tightens as his eyes shift to Phainon.

“What would you know? You’re nothing to us, but an outlander.” He all but spits at Phainon, his frustration visible. “Don’t speak on matters you have no knowledge of.” Eyes shifting back at Mydei.

As Krateros continues, Mydei feels the weight of his words pressing down on him, heavier than any crown or title ever could. His gaze shifts, just slightly, toward Phainon, though he doesn't meet his eyes. The air between them hums with unspoken tension. He doesn't know if it's his own exhaustion- or if it's Phainon's subtle, quiet watchfulness that makes the room feel smaller, suffocating.

Krateros doesn't pause, doesn't see the way Mydei's hands shake at his side, trying to calm himself down. He speaks as if Mydei hasn't heard him a thousand times before. "Your people need you, Mydeimos. Your mother has left me to raise you into a Prince, the next ruler of Castrum Kremnos. You are the son of Gorgo, so step up to your position! The people, they need their leader- *your* leadership. You've hidden away long enough."

The words slip under Mydei's skin like shards of glass, drawing blood with every syllable. He opens his mouth to speak, but nothing comes out. His throat feels tight, and for a moment, the room tilts. The faces around him blur. He feels the press of old stone walls, the heat of war, the scent of blood, the screams that never cease to echo in his mind. Castrum Kremnos. Once long ago, his home. His *grave* .

He doesn't know when his chest starts tightening, but suddenly he feels as if there's no room to breathe. It's not just the weight of Krateros' words, though they settle on him like an iron shackle. It's the weight of what it would mean to go back. To face it all again. The battles. The deaths. The lives he couldn't save.

His fingers curl involuntarily into fists, and he focuses on the feeling of the gauntlet pressing into his skin. Focus. He can't let anyone see. Not Krateros, not Phainon, no one.

But as the silence stretches, his thoughts spiral out of control. He remembers the burning of Castrum Kremnos, the way the sky had been painted with the glow of fire as the last of his people fell around him.

He remembers Castorice falling despite her powers as Thanatos' coreflame bearer, Tribbie's lifeless body. He remembers the warmth of crimson blood

flowing from the wound on his back, as he fell at the same place his father had forsaken him.

“Are you listening, Mydeimos?” Krateros’ voice cuts through the fog, and Mydei blinks hard, forcing his focus back to the present.

He forces a breath into his lungs, steadying himself. “I’m not hiding,” he says, his voice rougher than he expects. “I’m just... I’m just thinking about it. Thinking about what’s best for everyone.”

Krateros scoffs, his gaze cutting through him. “You don’t have time for indecision. *We* don’t have time.”

We . It’s too much. The pressure. The responsibility.

Before he can respond, he feels Phainon shift beside him, like a shadow at his back. He doesn’t look at him, doesn’t need to. But he feels the weight of Phainon’s hand close to his side. Phainon’s hand hovering just beside his waist, though not touching him. It’s a silent reminder.

He clenches his jaw to keep from shaking. He can’t- *won’t* - break. Not in front of Krateros. Not in front of anyone.

“I’m... I’m just not sure if I can lead them as they expect of me to.” Mydei whispers under his breath, the words so quiet that only he hears them. But the weight of them almost crushes him.

Krateros doesn’t hear. Krateros never hears him.

He opens his mouth to speak again, but this time, it’s Phainon’s voice that cuts through the fog. “That’s enough.” It’s not a suggestion. It’s an order. Phainon’s voice is quiet, but it carries a weight that no one, least of all Krateros, can ignore.

Mydei’s breath stutters at the sound of Phainon’s words, but he doesn’t look at him. Doesn’t let himself show the relief that surges through him, as if Phainon’s presence can steady him, can hold him together.

Krateros stares at Phainon for a long moment, but Phainon doesn’t break his gaze. Finally, Krateros sighs, though there’s no softness in it. “Fine. We’ll talk about this later.”

Mydei doesn’t acknowledge the dismissal. His chest is still tight, still suffocating. His mind is still drifting to Castrum Kremnos, to deaths he can no longer count, endless nights locked into fight with nothing but Nikador’s taunting voice in his head.

But for now, he doesn’t let it consume him. Not yet.

He doesn’t let himself show the pain.

Not until they’re alone.

The silence in the room is heavy, suffocating once Krateros leaves, and it is just him and Phainon once again. Mydei stands by the table, his eyes running over maps and scrolls, but not taking it all in really. His fingers grip the edge of the stone, his knuckles white from the tension that coils tight in his chest. He can feel the faintest tremor in his hands, but he refuses to let it show.

The weight of Krateros’ words lingers, heavy and oppressive. *You’ve hidden away long enough.*

Mydei’s eyes flicker to the window and outside to the sky, to the artificial sun that glows proud in the distance. His thoughts are far from peaceful, far from the hopes he once had of a future where he could find some semblance of peace. Now, all that’s left is an endless storm inside him, swirling between guilt, fear, and uncertainty. He’s not ready to go back. He doesn’t want to.

The past- the endless battles and the crushing weight of responsibility haunts him. The faces of the fallen Kremnoans blur in his mind like an unstoppable tide, their voices rising again in his thoughts, screaming in their last moments. The guilt presses down, suffocating. Every time he closes his eyes, he’s back in Castrum Kremnos. He’s back on the battlefield.

He can feel it. The pull, the expectation. *You must go back. You must lead them.*

But how can he? How can he lead them when he's broken, when he doesn't even know what *he* wants anymore? Who he wants to be, what he wants to do. Once upon a time, when he still dared to dream of a life after the war, before his countless deaths have broken him, he wished to live a quiet and peaceful life away from people's watchful eyes. Not as the prince of Castrum Kremnos, not as Mydeimos the Undying. Just as Mydei. Just as himself.

A soft noise from his side snaps him back into the present. He doesn't have to turn to know it's Phainon. He knows Phainon's presence like he knows his own heartbeat. The years spent together on the battlefield and outside of it has made him more sensitive to the other man's presence than any enemy he might encounter on the battlefield.

"You should rest." Phainon's voice is quiet, but there's something in it that holds a thread of urgency. A quiet command.

Mydei shakes his head, though his breath still feels too shallow, too tight. "I'm fine."

Phainon steps closer, his presence as much of a weight as a comfort. Mydei can feel the heat radiating from him, his scent, always so close, always so familiar. But it's more than just the physical proximity. It's the way Phainon's silent presence makes himself known to others. Always drawing others' attention. The way he's always there, always watching, always guarding.

It's suffocating sometimes. But it's also safe, allowing Mydei to fall back when he is about to slip, there to pick him up without words.

Mydei's gaze shifts to Phainon's hands. One of them hovers near his side, close enough that he can feel the warmth of his touch without it actually making contact. Mydei knows that Phainon has been watching him since Krateros left, perhaps sensing the tension rising in him, feeling it shift in the air.

“Phainon, I...” Mydei starts, but he can’t find the words. His throat tightens again, a dull ache pressing down. He doesn’t want to say what’s really on his mind. He doesn’t want to admit how afraid he is.

He doesn’t want to admit how desperately he’s clinging to Phainon’s presence.

Phainon doesn’t need Mydei to finish. The quiet understanding between them is enough. His hand finally brushes against Mydei’s back, light, but firm enough to send a shiver down his spine, yearning for more, his body unfamiliar with such kindness and softness, trained in fights and bloodshed ever since a young age. The touch is comforting, even though it adds another layer to the pressure weighing on Mydei’s chest.

“You don’t have to decide anything now,” Phainon says softly, his voice steady and warm, a steady anchor for Mydei’s slipping mind. “Let’s go back now.” He says, guiding Mydei out, and back to Marmoreal Palace where their peace is short lived, Aglea calling them to a meeting with the council of elders.

The council hall is quiet, the air thick with tension. Aglaea stands at the head of the table, composed and resolute. The Chrysos Heirs are scattered around the room- silent, observant, waiting for her to take charge. On one side it is the council, on the other the Crysos Heirs and the outlanders, drawing an invisible line between the two parties. Mydei stands close to Phainon, his expression remains calm and unreadable. Phainon stands beside him, a quiet presence, while the rest of the Heirs sit with barely restrained attention.

The Elders, seated in their high-backed chairs, exchange murmurs, their eyes sharp with suspicion.Caenis, the most powerful among them, finally speaks, her voice thick with ancient authority.

“Lady Aglaea.” Caenis begins, her gaze narrowing. “You stand before us with this… proposition of yours. You speak of the sealing of our Titan, Kephale’s Sun- which your outlander friends call the Stellaron, the very

source of our strength against the black tide. And yet you ask us to sever it from our world as though it were an insignificant flame."

Aglaea's voice is steady as she responds, not flinching under the weight of Caenis' words. "Kephale's sun is no longer what it once was. It is no longer a beacon of prosperity- it is a danger, a growing threat. Maybe it never was. The Black Tide draws closer every day, and we cannot continue to allow this source of power to endanger everything we've built."

Etro, a younger Elder but no less passionate, leans forward, his eyes flicking to the other Elders for support. "You ask us to give up our sun, an ancient force that has given us dominion over this land for centuries. Without it, what will become of us? What will we be?"

The Goldweaver's gaze sharpens, but her tone remains calm, careful. "The power of Kephale's Sun is no longer something we control. It never had been, it was foolish to ever think that. It has attracted the Black Tide, bringing ruin and devastation to our world. Perhaps Kephale himself chose to hold it up and not let it touch our soil to stop the ruin it would bring up on our civilization. We must seal it, not for the sake of power, but for survival. We are talking about a future where the Black Tide no longer threatens us, where our people can finally live without fear."

The room falls into silence. The weight of Aglaea's words hangs in the air, heavy and charged with the gravity of the decision at hand. But the Elders are not so easily swayed.

Caenis, her brow furrowed, speaks again, her voice slow and deliberate. "And you think sealing Kephale's Sun will stop the Black Tide? You do not understand the forces at play here, Lady Aglaea. That sun is not just our power, it is our connection to the Titans, to Kephale himself! To sever it would be to sever the very heart of Amphoreus. The chaos that would follow-"

"We have already seen the chaos." Aglaea cuts her off smoothly, her voice a soft but insistent command. "We've seen the death and destruction. We've felt the weight of the Black Tide creeping closer, like a shadow swallowing the light. It is no longer a question of control. It is a matter of stopping the

inevitable. Sealing Kephale’s sun is the only way to rid Amphoreus of the Black Tide once and for all. If we do nothing, it will continue to return, drawn back to us time and time again."

Murmurs ripple through the council. Another elder, an older woman with sharp eyes, scoffs. "And we are expected to simply trust these people? Outlanders, who appear from the void and promise salvation? You offer a solution, but what guarantee do we have that your interference will not bring another disaster? When you, Lady Aglaea yourself, was the one who made the choice to keep the people’s knowledge in the shadows about a universe outside of Amphoreus?"

A younger council member, seated near the edge, speaks up hesitantly. "If the Black Tide is truly drawn to Kephale’s sun, then logic dictates we must act. We cannot afford to let pride dictate our choices."

The first elder shakes her head, tone mocking as she speaks up once again. "And yet, I wonder- what of the Chrysos Heirs? You who once claimed divinity, who gave up everything for the Flamechase until the very end, what has it given you? If even your so-called enlightenment has not granted you the power to stop the Black Tide, was it ever worth it? If you have to rely on outlanders now, then what was the purpose of your pursuit? What is the purpose of giving up Kephale's sun, when even that is not sure to get rid of the black tide?”

The words cut deeper than the elder likely realizes. The room is silent, the weight of the accusation pressing down on them all.

The council chamber falls silent after the elder’s biting words. The question lingers in the air like smoke—sharp, cloying, impossible to ignore.

Was it worth it?

The Flame Chasers had reached divinity. They had ascended, burned through the trials, and emerged something more than human. They had wielded their power against the Black Tide, against the ruin that threatened Amphoreus. And yet, here they were, sitting at the same table as outlanders, begging for their intervention, their hard-earned powers not enough to save

Amphoreus. Or maybe they do not know of the choice of the Deliverer, who brings the new era to Amphoreus, nobody bothering to ask, and Phainon unwilling to give it away.

Mydei's fingers curl against his palm, hidden behind his back. His pulse thrums in his throat, each beat carrying the weight of memory.

He remembers his own deaths, too many to count, each one seared into his bones, into his soul. Phainon's hands, both saving and ending his life.

Was it worth it?

The words claw at him, bitter and relentless. What did divinity bring them, if not more suffering? If not more loss? The people of Amphoreus still suffered, still feared, still fought. The Black Tide had not been defeated in the past, only endured, and now they turned to outsiders to fix what the heirs, what he, could not.

Phainon shifts beside him, a barely perceptible movement, but Mydei feels it,his presence steady, waiting. Almost as if he knows. As if he sees the cracks forming on Mydei, on this parade of a meeting, just as he always does.

Mydei exhales slowly, keeping his expression neutral, his silence a shield.

Was it worth it?

He does not have an answer.

Phainon, usually so open with his feelings and thoughts, now stands with a straight face, letting out a slow breath. "Divinity was never the end goal of the Flame Chase journey." he says, voice even. "It was a means to survive, to fight. And we have fought, for lifetimes. But even we are bound by the limits of this world. You speak as if we have done nothing, yet you are able to still stand here because of what we endured."

Aglaea does not let the silence stretch, taking over the word from Phainon. "The question is not whether divinity was worth it. The question is whether

you will make the choice that ensures Amphoreus has a future. The Black Tide will return unless we act now. This is not a matter of pride or power, it is survival."

The council members exchange glances, their resistance wavering in the face of logic. The discussion continues, heated and tense, but step by step, an agreement begins to take shape.

Mydei walks slowly, exhaustion settling deep in his bones. The council meeting has lasted longer than he expected it to, wringing them all dry as the outlanders explained how the sealing would go and just what would happen after it. All the shouting and arguments tired him out. The conversation about the Stellaron, and the looming uncertainty of their future all swirl in his mind. He barely registers his own movements, lost in thought, his mind spiraling back to the unsettling exchanges with Krateros and the weight of decisions that hang over him.

He doesn’t fully remember how the discussion went, his mind slipping more often than not to pay attention during the whole meeting after their divinity was brought into question, his own poisonous mind taking over his thoughts. He faintly recalls the curious gaze of one of the outlanders following him, but he paid it no mind.

When he turns a corner, he nearly misses the shadow lingering just ahead. Black Swan stands there, idly shuffling her cards, the rhythmic sound whispering against the silence. Her presence is light, almost floating, as if she were a specter rather than flesh and blood.

"You seem troubled." she muses, her voice gentle, almost knowing, as though she already knows the answer.

Mydei slows, hesitating. He isn’t in the mood for riddles or cryptic words. But her tone pulls him in, whether he wants it or not. "I'm fine." he says automatically, though his voice lacks conviction.

She tilts her head, smiling faintly. "That word is used so often, yet it rarely holds truth." She draws a single card from her deck, turning it over between

her fingers with deliberate slowness. "Do you ever wonder why things persist? Why do certain pieces remain in play, even when the board is shattered?"

He frowns, caught off guard. "What are you talking about?"

Black Swan's eyes flick to him, bright and knowing, as if she can read the depths of him with a single glance. "You." she says simply. "You shouldn't be here, Lord Mydei. And yet, you are still alive, a miscalculation perhaps?"

A prickling sensation spreads over his skin. It's not an accusation, but something more, a truth she's not revealing. Mydei straightens, feeling a subtle wariness and unease creep into him. "I don't understand what you're implying, Miss." he says carefully, keeping his voice steady.

She sighs, almost theatrically, as though disappointed. "Perhaps it isn't time for you to understand." she murmurs softly. "Not yet."

Her fingers move over the deck again, a slow, absentminded motion as if she's caught in some faraway thought. Her eyes narrow thoughtfully. Her chest rises slowly with every breath she takes, her mysterious power lingering in the air around her. "But tell me… have you ever felt it? The weight of something just outside your reach? A shadow of a memory that doesn't belong to you?"

A flash of something unsettles him- old, fading memories, fragments of moments he shouldn't remember but somehow does. Inextricable memories tangling together. They vanish before he can grasp them, leaving him with a strange emptiness. He brushes it off quickly. "No," he says firmly, his voice more controlled this time. "I haven't."

Black Swan smiles knowingly, as if she expected that answer. "Of course." She tucks the card back into the deck, tapping it gently against her palm. "Some truths take time to unravel. Some things refuse to be forgotten."

Mydei exhales sharply, frustration building. "If you have something to say, then say it." he insists, feeling a pull to get to the heart of whatever this is.

She steps closer, her presence unnervingly light, like a shadow shifting through the air, brushing against him. "Some things cannot be said, only understood. But if you listen closely, you might hear them in the silence between heartbeats. That friend of yours, reminds me of a dear friend of mine. Once we danced in her mind- a terrific experience truly. He seems to be the same." She sighs, almost dreamily almost lost in her own thoughts, sending shivers down Mydei’s spine.

His patience begins to wear thin, frustration pooling in his chest. "Enough with the riddles." he mutters, turning away, his footsteps sharp against the stone floor.

Before he can take another step, he stops almost walking into someone. A presence that’s unmistakable.

"Mydei."

Phainon’s voice is low, steady, carrying a weight that immediately pulls Mydei's attention. It’s not urgent, not angry, but there's something in it, something that makes the air feel heavier.

Mydei doesn’t look up. He doesn’t need to.

Black Swan’s gaze flickers past him to Phainon, and for the first time, something shifts in her expression. It’s not fear, not surprise- just quiet acknowledgment, like an unspoken understanding.

Phainon steps forward, close enough that Mydei can feel the heat of him, like a shield wrapping around him. "You should go." he says, his voice calm, but firm, leaving no room for argument. “Your companions have been looking for you.”

Black Swan smiles, a small, knowing curve of her lips. "Of course," she says, her tone almost soft, but there's an undercurrent of something else- pity, perhaps?- as her gaze shifts back to Mydei before speaking again. "Take care, Lord Mydeimos. And… don’t forget to listen to your dreams."

With that, she turns, her silhouette slipping silently into the shadows, leaving Mydei with nothing but the quiet hum of his own thoughts.

The silence that stretches between Mydei and Phainon is thick, laden with unspoken words. Phainon doesn’t speak immediately, and Mydei feels the tension in the air, the weight of the conversation he almost had. Then, after a long moment, Phainon’s hand brushes lightly over his arm- not firm, not urgent, just steady, grounding.

"Are you alright?" Phainon’s voice is soft, but there’s a quiet insistence beneath the calm, as if he can sense something, though he doesn’t press.

Mydei takes a moment before nodding, though his mind is still tangled in Black Swan’s words, in the weight of what he can’t remember. "I’m fine."

Phainon doesn’t pull away immediately. His presence lingers, solid and unwavering, like a steady anchor in the swirling sea of Mydei’s thoughts. Mydei doesn’t know if it’s too much. He doesn’t know if he should step away.

But for now, he lets it be, letting Phainon’s quiet strength anchor him as the world continues to shift around them.

The sky above Amphoreus is eerily still, the artificial sun burning with a hollow brilliance in Kephale’s hands, the Titan looms in the distance, its massive form stretching across the horizon, silent and motionless as the final preparations for the Stellaron’s sealing unfold.

Mydei stands with Phainon at the Path of Parting, a bit of privacy from the mass of spectators at the baths and the Garden of Life, gazing toward the titan. It has been there for as long as they have known, a guardian, a god, and now- soon to be a relic of the past. The thought unsettles him in a way he cannot name.

"Do you think this will really work?" Phainon's voice is low, carrying an edge of doubt despite his usual confidence.

"It has to." Mydei replies, though the words taste uncertain on his tongue, his own doubts catching up to him.

The council’s words still ring in his head, their doubt, their accusations- had their ascension been worth it? They reached divinity, but in the end, what had it changed? He was no god, not truly. He had bled and burned and lost like anyone else. He had fought and failed, had stood on the precipice of something greater and found only ruin waiting for him.

He looks down at his hands. Once, he had believed they could shape the future. A better future for his people, for the whole of Amphoreus. Now, he isn’t sure anymore.

He watches as Welt and the others move below, their forms small against the vastness of the titan’s feet in the distance. The sealing is methodical, runic inscriptions lighting up the sky, wrapping around the Stellaron with careful precision. It is the brown haired man wearing glasses, who does the work with his cane, the other outlanders spectators as the people of Amphoreus themself. Mydei wonders just how strong these outlanders truly are. He can feel the shift in the air, an ancient force bending, resisting, then slowly giving way.

Phainon exhales sharply beside him. "Kephale has held this thing for so long. It’s hard to imagine the sky without it."

Mydei nods, but his gaze lingers on the titan’s unmoving form. There is no resistance, no reaction. And that silence unsettles him more than anything else.

“Maybe they never intended to hold it up for so long.” Mydei muses, more to himself than to Phainon.

Phainon glances at him. "What do you mean?"

Before Mydei can answer, the sealing reaches its final stage. The inscriptions converge in a sudden burst of light, wrapping around the Stellaron like chains of pure radiance. The sky trembles. The entire world seems to hold its breath.

Then, something gives.

The Stellaron vanishes into its prison, locked away beyond reach.

Kephale crumbles.

The titan's form, once so vast and unshakable, begins to break apart like ancient stone eroding under an unseen force. The golden light dims, revealing the truth beneath: the body is hollow, a corpse that has been holding up the false sun for far too long.

The first crack splits down its spine. Then the arms give way, crumbling into dust, all four of them falling to the ground. The sky shakes as the titan collapses, its weight sinking into the land.

For a moment there is no sound around them, everyone forgetting how to breathe. Then, pain lances through Mydei's body.

His breath catches. A white-hot sensation pierces his back, right where the phantom scar of his death still lingers. He staggers, fingers clawing at his ribs as if he can tear the pain away. The shrill ends of his gauntlets cut into his skin, drawing golden liquid. The world spins, the sky darkens at the edges of his vision. His knees give way before he realizes he's falling.

He barely registers Phainon's voice- sharp, panicked. Hands grab him, steadying him, but the pain doesn't stop.

It spreads, blooming like fire through his bones.

He can feel wetness trickle down his back, and as he glances down crimson blood mixing with gold falls on the ground under him- his own blood.

His vision flickers, and for a moment, just a moment, Phainon's eyes glow with an eerie light, mirroring the remnants of Kephale's dying radiance.

Mydei gasps, trying to pull away, but the world tilts again, and he feels himself being caught before he can hit the ground. The pain burns, his mind fraying at the edges, and through it all, he hears Phainon's voice- low, desperate, his name repeated like a prayer.

"Mydei- Mydei, stay with me. Look at me. Please."

There is panic in his voice. True panic, it reminds Mydei of their fight in Castrum Kremnos.

Mydei tries. Tries to focus, to ground himself, to push away the visions clawing at him. The Titan crumbles. The false sun fades. The weight of the past presses against him, suffocating.

He grips Phainon’s arm, grounding himself in something real. In someone real. His blood is flowing freely from a wound that was never supposed to be there anymore in this world.

Then darkness takes him.

The first thing Mydei registers is warmth- too much of it, suffocating in its weight. His body feels leaden, his mind sluggish, thoughts slipping through his fingers like water. He blinks against the dim light, his vision slow to adjust, but even before he fully comes to, he knows where he is.

Phainon's chambers.

The scent is unmistakable- embers and spice, something deep and lingering beneath it, a presence that has wrapped itself around him more times than he can count. The sheets beneath him are soft, familiar, and his body aches as though he has been fighting in his sleep. A phantom pressure lingers between his shoulder blades, a ghost of pain that is neither here nor there.

Then he hears it. A voice, low, muttered, just above a whisper.

"-won’t leave. You won’t leave. You’re here, you’re here, you’re still here."

Mydei's breath stutters as he turns his head, sluggish, only to find Phainon beside him. He sits in a chair, close enough that his forearms rest on the edge of the mattress, his fingers curled tightly into the sheets. He leans over Mydei, golden eyes flickering, his lips parted as he whispers to himself. He seems out of it, not even noticing that Mydei has woken up.

Mydei has never seen him like this.

Phainon's usual easy grace is gone. His shoulders are tense, his posture too still, as if any movement might shatter something delicate. His eyes roam over Mydei’s body but not focused, his breath unsteady.

“Phainon,” Mydei croaks, voice raw.

The whispering stops instantly. Phainon's head snaps up, and for a moment, his expression is unreadable- something caught between desperate relief and the remnants of panic. Then, just as quickly, his face smooths over, the lines of his mouth softening.

"You're awake." The words are steady, but his grip on the sheets tightens before he releases them, flexing his fingers as if forcing himself to move.

Mydei shifts, trying to sit up, but his body protests, his limbs sluggish. The moment he struggles Phainon is there, pressing a hand against his shoulder, firm but careful. "Don't.” he says, a thread of urgency in his voice. "Just stay."

“You-” Phainon exhales sharply, raking a hand through his hair before settling again. “You scared the hell out of me.”

The words are steady, but his jaw tightens.

Mydei huffs a quiet breath, shifting against the sheets. “I’m fine.”

A scoff. “You collapsed.”

“…Yet here I am.”

Phainon’s gaze sharpens. Something flashes behind his eyes.

A beat of silence.

“Don’t do that.”

Mydei stills. “Do what?”

“Act like it’s nothing.” The words are soft but firm. “Like you didn’t just-” He stops himself, exhales. Runs a hand down his face, seeming tired, his hair a mess. “You wouldn’t wake up.” His voice drops lower, rough around the edges as his eyes open,and looks into Mydei’s eyes, his gaze intense.

“I thought-” Another breath. “It doesn’t matter.”

Mydei studies him. Phainon’s hands, usually so relaxed, are curled into loose fists as they land in his lap. His shoulders are stiff, tension lining the set of his jaw.

“How long was I out?” Mydei asks after a moment.

“... for days.” Phainon’s voice is devoid of emotions as he speaks, gaze boring into Mydei’s soul.

“Did you stay here the whole time?” Mydei asks again, already knowing the answer, yet his heart still beats faster hearing Phainon say it.

“Of course I did.”

As if it were obvious. As if there had never been another option.

A silence lingers between them, heavier than before. Mydei exhales, pressing a palm over his forehead. His body still feels off- something lingers, something echoes- but he does not know what.

Phainon shifts, his gaze flicking over him again. “You should rest.”

“Mm.” Mydei hums noncommittally, letting his eyes close again, if only to ease the weight behind them.

Phainon doesn’t move.

The knock on the door is sharp and impatient. Mydei barely has time to gather himself before it comes again, voices from outside seeping in through the heavy wooden door. He does not notice the way Phainon’s hands clench eyes shifting to the door.

“Mydei should be resting among his people.” Krateros’ voice carries through the door, firm with expectation. “Not locked away here.”

Phainon tenses beside him, his hand still resting on the edge of the bed where he had been watching over Mydei. His gaze sharpens, the warmth from moments ago cooling into something unreadable.

“You’re too loud.” Anaxa’s voice snaps from the other side. “He is still out of it.”

“All the more reason for him to be with us.” Krateros argues. “He was hurt, wasn’t he? You expect me to leave him here when he should be under Kremnoan care?”

A shuffle follows- a rustle of fabric, a barely audible sigh from another Chrysos Heir.

Phainon doesn’t move. Doesn’t answer.

Mydei exhales, running a hand down his face. His body still feels sluggish, his thoughts disjointed, but he forces himself to sit up fully. “It’s fine,” he murmurs. “Let him in.”

Phainon turns to him sharply, something unreadable flashing across his face. He doesn’t argue, but his fingers tighten on the sheets before he pulls away, straightening his back as he sits tall in his chair.

The door creaks open.

Mydei sits upright in his bed, still sore, but his golden eyes are steady as the argument unfolds before him. Krateros stands at the threshold, shoulders squared as he glances around in the room, eyes settling on Mydei.

"Good, you have woken up. You should be resting in the settlement." Krateros says, his voice like grinding stone together. "Among your own. Or do you no longer consider yourself Kremnoan?"

Mydei exhales slowly, feeling the weight of that question press against his chest, but before he can answer, Phainon speaks.

"He's where he should be. In safety." Phainon says, his tone deceptively calm, but there is a sharpness beneath it. "Unless you plan to tear him from this room yourself."

Krateros' gaze flickers to him, narrowing. "You speak as if you have a right to keep him here."

Phainon tilts his head, a slow, deliberate motion, his blue eyes unwavering. "And you speak as if I haven't already honored the customs of Kremnos. It's you who refuses to acknowledge it and keeps pushing for Mydei to go back when his place is right next to me."

A ripple of silence follows, heavy and expectant. Mydei watches as Krateros stiffens, as if struck. The meaning in Phainon’s words lingers between them, something unspoken yet undeniable. Mydei glances between them, his confusion carefully concealed. He doesn’t understand what Phainon means, but Krateros clearly does.

The elder's lips press into a thin line. "That is a bold claim."

"It’s not a claim." Phainon counters. "It’s the truth. You just refuse to accept it."

Mydei can feel the atmosphere shift, as if something vast and unseen looms beneath their words. He knows better than to ask outright. But whatever it is, it is something Krateros will not easily forgive, his teacher ever the one to hold grudge against others.

The silence stretches until Krateros exhales sharply. "Fine. Stay here if you wish, Mydeimos. But if you truly are Kremnoan, then act like it. Your people have not forgotten you."

With that, he turns and walks away, his steps echoing through the corridor.

Phainon watches him go, his expression unreadable. But when Mydei looks at him, Phainon meets his gaze and smiles- soft, triumphant, unwavering.

And Mydei, still lost in the depths of a conversation he doesn't fully understand, can only nod in return.

The room is still. Silent, save for the soft, steady rhythm of his breathing and the gentle wind that brushes against the stone of the window. Mydei is awake, though his body still feels foreign to him, a lingering fatigue pressing against his chest as he pushes himself to sit up. This is new, even after his deaths his symptoms did not last for such a long time. His head is heavy, his thoughts clouded with the aftershocks of everything that has happened, and yet a strange pull drags his attention to the window.

His gaze drifts toward the source of the subtle change, toward the dark expanse of the sky. For the first time in what feels like a lifetime, Mydei’s eyes meet the night, real night.

“Today is the first time it actually became night.” Phainon talks quietly by his side, once he notices where Mydei’s attention shifted.

“So far, it only grew darker each day, never truly becoming night. It seems like you waking up brought back the balance to Amphoreus.” He speaks as if he is letting Mydei in on a secret, a mischievous smile on his face that softens once he notices the blonde Prince not paying attention to him. He watches him, as Mydei watches the sky.

It’s impossible to explain, but the absence of Kephale’s sun is a profound void. There’s a chill to the air now, an unfamiliar coolness that hasn’t touched this land in eons. The constant day that Kephale’s sun had provided is gone, leaving the world draped in something quiet, something vast.

Mydei watches the stars.

Stars.

They are small and cold, scattered across the ink-black sky like fragments of a broken mirror. His heart trembles at their cold beauty. He doesn’t remember the last time he saw them, but they feel like a distant memory, like something that belongs to another life.

He feels something tug inside him, a quiet ache that pulls at his chest, deeper than the emotional wounds that still have yet to heal. The vastness of the sky stretches on before him, and in that endless space, something feels lost, something he can't quite name.

Mydei's lips part, his breath a soft whisper as his gaze drifts down to the dark expanse. It's all he's ever known, that eternal daylight. The sun that never sets. But now... now, it is gone, and all that remains is this vast, empty sky.

"I've never seen it like this before," Mydei says quietly, his voice still raw, as if waking from a long, unsettling dream. "The stars. It feels... strange. Like the world has changed."

Phainon is silent for a moment, his gaze following Mydei's to the sky. Mydei can feel the weight of the silence, heavy with an emotion Phainon doesn't voice.

"It is strange." Phainon agrees, his voice soft. "The world is changing, Mydei. Kephale's sun is no longer here, and with it, the tide of chaos that followed it. We can rest now. You can let your responsibilities go. It is done now."

Mydei's chest tightens, and a wave of confusion washes over him. He stares at the stars as if they might hold the answers, as if somehow their cold, distant light can explain the emptiness he feels inside himself.

"There's nothing left for me to hold on to." Mydei whispers, almost to himself. The silence presses in around him. It feels like he is telling Phainon his deepest, darkest secret, one that he will regret once his right mind comes back and Mydei isn't tired. The night feels like an old wound, reopened. For so long, the sky had been a constant, a source of warmth, of light. Now, it is void, empty of everything but the cold.

"Hold on to me, Mydei. I will give you a new reason to live for." Phainon says softly, his voice gentle but laden with something Mydei can't quite place. He reaches out, fingers touches Mydei's bare hands, sending shivers down his spine.

Mydei looks down at his hands, fingers trembling as they rest on the blanket, Phainon's hand enveloping his own. He feels... adrift. Like a part of him has been severed, torn away, and he doesn't know how to make sense of it. How to make sense of this new life.

Phainon shifts beside him, and Mydei can feel his presence- solid, warm, steady. Yet it doesn't settle the storm inside him.

"You've never seen it like this, Mydei." Phainon says again, his voice thick with unspoken emotion as his eyes shift back to the vastness of the night sky. "You've never seen the sky without the sun."

Mydei takes a deep breath, trying to steady himself, but the weight of everything pressing on him feels unbearable. "I don't know what to make of it. It's beautiful thought." he confesses. His voice cracks slightly, and he swallows, his throat tight as his eyes take in the countless glinting stars. "The world is changing, but I feel like I'm stuck. I don't even know what I'm supposed to do anymore."

"The world is always changing," Phainon says, his voice softer now, almost a whisper. "But you're not alone. Not anymore. We'll find our way through this, Mydei. I'll be here." He repeats his silent promise to him.

Mydei doesn't respond right away. He doesn't know how to. Instead, he turns back to the window, his gaze locked on the stars once more. The emptiness of the sky mirrors the emptiness in him, and yet, there's a strange sort of comfort in that void. It's raw, unyielding, and it feels like the beginning of something he hasn't yet come to understand.

For the first time in his life, the night sky is his, so similar to the evernight sky he faced when stepping ashore from the River of Souls. It's cold, unfamiliar, but it's his to face.

The night may be endless. But so are their new opportunities.

And for the first time in centuries, feeling afraid of the unknown does not send unease down Mydei's spine. Not with Phainon by his side.

Chapter End Notes

Well!

I hope everyone enjoyed the new chapter, I know I enjoyed writing it! I know that Dan Heng said that there is no Stellaron in Amphoreus, but I much rather have that- because the leaks I saw of the story I do not like LOL so this because canon-divergent real quickly hahaha.

Timeline is.... most confusing. First I had in mind to make Stelle go back to the very first moment they arrived to Amphoreus to have Trianne live- but I realised while proofreading this chapter that I messed up because Mydei took the coreflame and his people made a statue for him. So let's just ignore that mess in the timelines- Mydei's trial happened- so did everyone else's but also everyone is alive. How? Well- thanks to our special trashpanda MC!

Comments and kudos are most appreciated!

End Notes

Hello everyone!

I hope that the first chapter was good enough to catch your attention. I do not promise an update schedule, but I will try to bring the next chapter as soon as I can.

I do not have a specific chapter number in mind, the story will focus on Mydei's healing after the war and getting used to simple life. That's the plot of it, really.... spiced with my obsession with Phainon wanting to get Mydei pregnant because that's just canon in my head sorry not sorry!

Fic name is from Hozier's Abstract song, I can't tell you the amount of times I listened to Unreal Unearth while writing haha.

Anyways, if you want to scream about phaidei with me, find you can find me on twitter!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!